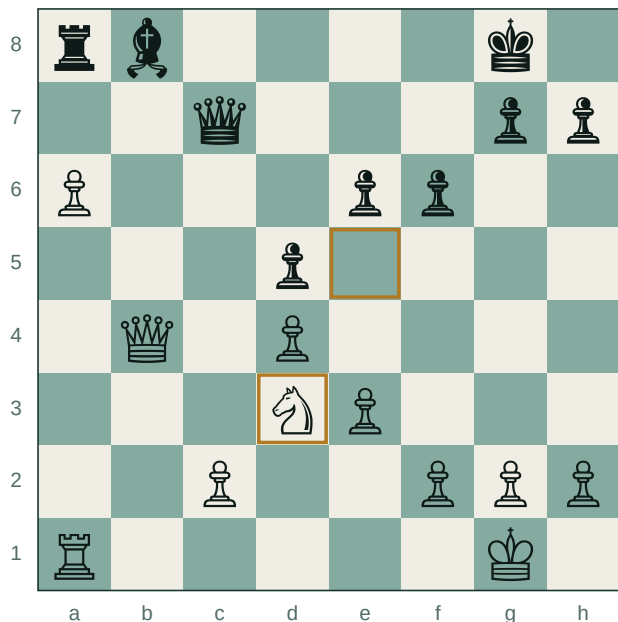


Skewers: Black, move 26

Skewers

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Nd3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Qxh2+ 27. Kf1 Qh1+ 28. Ke2 Qxa1

26...Qxh2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on h2. Recorded reply: **27.Kf1**.

27...Qh1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **28.Ke2**.

28...Qxa1 The queen captures the rook on a1.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -2 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The defender may block, capture the attacker, or protect the rear piece while moving the front one. Alignment alone is not enough.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A skewer puts the more important target in front. When that target moves, a piece behind it may be lost. Checks make the geometry especially forcing.

HOW TO LOOK

Search ranks, files, and diagonals where two enemy pieces line up. Calculate the first target's legal responses.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.